

How I Became a Ghost Ch. 23-24

By Tim Tingle





Chapter 23

Naomi and the Bonepickers

I KNEW NAOMI needed me, now more than ever. I slipped through the walls of the trunk. I was learning when to disappear and when to be seen. I let my body give off a soft glow, slowly coming to life before her eyes.

“Do everything they say and you will be safe,” I whispered. “Joseph will be nearby, to warn us when the soldiers come. They’ll never find you here.”

“Why do they want a bloody animal?” Naomi asked.

“I don’t know. We’ll have to wait and see.”

We didn’t have long to wait. After only a few minutes, Panther Joseph caught a fat raccoon. He dragged the dead raccoon across the ground,

then crouched and leapt into the wagon, dropping the raccoon before the bonepickers.

I lifted my arms and floated through the top of the trunk. I wanted to see what the woman would do with a bloody dead raccoon. Panther Joseph had done what she asked. The raccoon was slashed and cut from head to tail.

Panther teeth cuts , I thought.

A thick trail of blood stretched across the floor of the wagon. The woman took the raccoon by the neck and flung it in a circle over her head. Blood flew everywhere, on the walls, the trunk, and all over the woman. She lifted the lid of the trunk and held the raccoon over the pile of bones.

As I watched, the woman squeezed the raccoon tight and wrung it out, like she was squeezing water from a wet towel.

Blood dripped on the bones.

“Oh!” Naomi shouted.

I returned to the trunk and hovered over Naomi.

"I'm here, Naomi," I said.

"Help me," Naomi whispered.

Blood dripped through the cracks in the floor and fell like raindrops on Naomi's face.

"Nooo," she cried.

"Shhhhh," said the woman. "We have to do this. Once the soldiers look in the trunk, they'll leave us alone."

"She's right, Naomi," I whispered. "Nothing scares *Nahullos* like bloody bones."

"I think I'd rather be a ghost," said Naomi.

"Don't think like that. What about your mother and father? One ghost daughter is enough."

"You're right," she said. "*Hoke*, just get me out of here as soon as you can."

"I'll do my best, but I have to leave you now."

Luke and Joseph waited for me by the river. The snow fell thick and they were shivering cold. Bits of blood and raccoon fur dotted Joseph's face and hair.

"You should wash up before anybody sees you," I told him.

“Oh, sorry,” said Joseph. He grabbed a handful of snow and washed himself clean.

“How long will Naomi stay with the bonepickers?” he asked.

“Till it’s safe,” Luke answered. “Remember they are looking for a girl with short hair, cut like a boy’s. The women have a plan to hide Naomi in plain sight. They are weaving a long hairpiece for her to wear.”

“It might work,” said Joseph. “For now, Isaac and I will wait here. We’ll let you know when anything happens,” Joseph said.

“I’ll do the same,” Luke promised. “I need to get back to the family. *Chi pisa lachike.*”

“Don’t go yet,” a deep voice said.

Luke stopped in his tracks. He stood speechless, his eyes filled with wonder. A thick white cloud covered us, and when it lifted, Old Man stood among us.

I am the only ghost Luke has ever seen, I thought. He's entering my world now, the living place of ghosts.

"We want to tell you three young men how proud we are of what you have done today," Old Man said.

He nodded and lifted his arms. In the dark of the woods the air trembled with light. One by one they appeared, until at least a hundred Choctaw ghosts encircled us.

They were the walking ones who never left us. In times of trouble they are there. We know this, but sometimes we must be reminded.

Our deeds touch not only the living. We did more than save Naomi today. We made our people proud. That is the highest honor a Choctaw can ever earn, to make the ancestors proud.

They spoke in a single voice and with a single word they honored us.

"Yakoke," they said. "Thank you."

As suddenly as they appeared, the ghosts were gone. Luke said not a word.

He looked at Joseph and me, then turned quickly and started home. When he thought we weren't looking, he broke into a run.

"He'll get used to it," said Joseph.

"He'd better," I said, "now that his little brother is a ghost."

Sometime after midnight the wind grew angry and sleet replaced the friendly snow. Watching the ice fall, I was glad to be a ghost. I couldn't feel

a thing. Joseph wrapped himself tight in my blanket, but I knew he was freezing. We couldn't risk a fire.

"The snow has covered our footprints," I said, "and the ice will slow them down in the morning."

"Yes, I'm glad for that," Joseph said, through chattering teeth. "Let's hope for more ice!"

As if in reply, a branch heavy with ice cracked and landed at our feet.

"Careful what you wish for," I reminded him.



Chapter 24

A Soldier's Vow

IN SPITE OF THE FREEZING cold, Joseph fell asleep in minutes. His blanket was soon covered in snow. I knew he was exhausted from the long day of rescuing Naomi, setting fire to the soldiers' camp, rushing Naomi to the bonepickers' wagon, and catching a raccoon with his bare teeth!

I sat watching him sleep. I was neither tired nor cold.

Life is very different as a ghost, I told myself. I learned something else that night: Without sleep, life as a ghost can be boring!

That must be why ghosts know everything, I thought. *While everybody else is sleeping, they float around and see what's happening.*

I closed my eyes tight and imagined the soldiers' camp. When I opened them, I stood by the burning wagon. The soldiers had tried to put the fire out with buckets of snow, but the wagon was destroyed. Piles of smoking embers were all that remained.

Roundman leaned against a tree, wide-awake, with his shotgun over his lap. The other soldiers were asleep in their wagons. I searched the wagons till I found Leader. He was tossing and turning, adrift in a nightmare of the fire and Naomi's escape.

"I will kill you for this!" he called out in his sleep.

His anger was strong, and I knew he would seek revenge in the morning. I returned to my family's camp. Everyone was safe and sound asleep. Nita lay between her mother and father. She smiled and waved at me.

"Where have you been?" Jumper asked.

“Jumper,” I said, “I’ve missed you!”

“Yeah, life’s not the same without you, either.”

“Is everything *hoke*?” I asked.

“*Hoke* for now, but stay close in the morning. Trouble’s coming. That’s what everybody says.”

“Well, everybody is right. The soldiers will be looking for you, you know.”

“How’d you like my little act?” Jumper said with pride. “I jumped in the river and got their attention, so you and Joseph could save Naomi. That water was cold, but it was worth it.”

“You were great, Jumper! But this battle is not over quite yet,” I said. “Get some sleep, and I’ll see you in the morning.”

"Chi pisa lachike," Jumper said. When he saw the surprised look on my face, he added, "What? You never heard a dog speak Choctaw before?"

"Jumper, you have to be the smartest dog in the world!"

"Yakoke," said Jumper.

I waved good-bye as I floated away.

The light of day came slow and quiet that morning. No red streaks in the sky announced the sunrise. I circled the soldiers' camp till one by one they rolled out of bed and joined Leader by the campfire.

"Stay together today," Leader said. "We will find the girl. She and her family will pay. Feed the horses well and carry extra shotgun shells. If anyone runs, shoot them."

"Do you want anyone to guard the camp?" asked Pointy Nose.

"No!" shouted Leader. He grabbed his shotgun and walked slowly to Pointy Nose. "Ask me that again," he said, in a low and menacing voice.

"Do . . . you want anyone . . . to guard the camp?" Pointy Nose stammered.

Leader tilted his hat to the back of his head and looked to the sky. Every soldier stared at him, unsure of what he would do next. Leader took a step back, lifted his shotgun to his shoulder, and swung it hard at the skinny soldier.

Pointy Nose fell to the ground, with blood flowing from a cut on his forehead.

“Do you have your answer?” Leader shouted. “No guards! You are not getting out of this!”

Roundman leapt to his friend and wrapped a cloth around his head. Blood soaked through the cloth, and Roundman packed the wound with snow to stop the bleeding.

“Now,” said Leader, “saddle your horses and let’s go. We will search every wagon, starting with the Choctaw Council’s. Climb in the wagons and search in every corner. When you find the girl, bring her to me.”

As the soldiers mounted their horses and stepped to the icy road, Leader shouted, “Someone will die today.”